The place where tradition meets the future. The anomalies that made Rifò an interesting case study for the textile district of Prato.

by Daniela Toccafondi

Introduction

The concept of sustainability is becoming increasingly important, not only for the apparel industry. But as everyone knows, Fashion is based on trends and the product has, as a result, a short life cycle. The emergence of ready-to-wear fashion has also shortened the life cycle and made the quantities produced larger with a significant reduction in consumer prices. The consequence is a progressive accumulation of unsold, discarded clothes and waste. The precise negative environmental impact of the fashion industry remains unknown. Thanks to trade liberalization, globalization, and enduring cost pressures, most well-known brands outsource final production. McKinsey has recently estimated that the carbon impact of the industry is 4% of overall global carbon emissions.[1]

Even in the fashion system, a product is considered sustainable not only because it is made with sustainable raw materials but substantially because it is the result of a sustainable process. Furthermore, sustainability is not only synonymous with attention to the environment in suitable products, but also with respect for production processes, working conditions, worker's rights, and attention to poverty and needy categories. Sustainability is a dynamic and continuous process; it is not an immutable state but one that is constantly evolving. Sustainability starts at the beginning of the supply chain and significantly involves the early stages.

Contextual Framework

Prato has always been a place where attention to sustainability is very strong, due to the specific nature of the typical product made in the area: carded wool yarns and fabrics, and regenerated wool productions. By now this statement is widely shared by experts, journalists, and professionals. [2] the concept of re-use is rooted in the culture of the territory, as demonstrated by the theatrical performance "Stracci" (*Rags*) developed in 2008 by the talented director Tommaso Santi and performed inside the production warehouse. Repurpose in 2014 thanks to funding achieved through crowdfunding, more recently Tommaso Santi together with Silvia Gambi produced a docufilm ("Stracci") that was screened to all interested sector operators within the Premiere Vision Exhibition in 2022.

One of the most important Prato academics, Giacomo Becattini, emphasized the great peculiarity of Prato's organizational model, made up of a myriad of small and medium-size family-owned companies specializing only in certain phases of the supply chain.[3]

The Municipality of Prato, with its approximately 194 thousand inhabitants, confirms itself as the third-largest city in central Italy, after Rome and Florence. The manufacturing system has a great tradition in the textile sector of the medium market and high range, but in recent years the clothing sector has been affirmed thanks to a large immigration of Chinese citizens who are dedicated to ready-to-wear fashion (products of low price that have the characteristic of being reabsorbed in a very short time). The Prato district extends well beyond the boundaries of the province of Prato

involving areas belonging to the province of Pistoia and Florence. Prato has 7 thousand textile and apparel companies (2.500 textile companies and 4.500 clothing companies)[4], each with a hyperspecialization according to a supply chain that can be divided into phases. Over the years, that typical organization, based on phases with a large number of independent companies, has implemented the knowledge of economic operators and has guaranteed very large specific investments.

At the Italian level, Prato is the territory with the highest number of employed in textiles – 18.520 in 2019 (Source: Confindustria Toscana Nord). At the same time, it is the province with the highest number of employees in apparel (24.447 in 2019 according to the indications of Confindustria. Istat data tells us that there were 19.169 employed in apparel in 2017 representing 11.2% of the total apparel workforce with an increase from 2001 to 2017 of +296.8%). Prato is also the Italian district that exports the most textile products (yarns, fabrics, clothing) for a total amount of 2,8 million euros approximately (Source: Confindustria Toscana Nord). With this consistent manufacturing endowment, the city remains in the middle of the league table in the analysis that Legambiente carries out every year on Italian cities.[5] There are various reasons for this, in part linked to the environmental characteristics of the area (very windy, rich in water, close to uncontaminated mountainous areas…) but in part linked to the right choices and environmentally friendly economic policies since the birth of the district. An important example is represented by the public-private joint-stock company GIDA spa, founded in 1981 for the purification, treatment, and recovery of civil and industrial wastewater. It is estimated that every day Gida spa avoids the production of 1982tons of carbon dioxide.

But the issue that is of most interest to frame the territory is that Prato has a strong characterization among traders as a place where wool is produced recycled from rags, packaging scraps, and production leftovers. This fame has been known since the 1950s. Prato began to specialize in textile in the 12th century, but it was at the end of the 19th century that the industrial expansion came, with the introduction of mechanization and geographic concentration. A significant expansion contribution was due to the lower costs of carded wool processing caused by the gradually increasing production of recovered wool obtained from shredding old clothes and industrial scarps. It is not just a question of sustainability of processes, for many years, in the Prato district, the issue of circular economy has been successfully tackled in many production processes. In short, In Prato, there was a circular economy long before the concept of circular economy spread among consumers all over the world.

According to the Ellen MacArthur Foundation, one of the world's leading institutes, the circular economy is defined as: "an economy designed to be able to regenerate itself. The circular economy is a system in which all activities, starting with extraction and production, are organized so that someone's waste becomes a resource for someone else." The textile district of Prato is the place where the circular economy was everyday life right from the beginning.

This is the framework in which Rifò was established in 2017. The company does not keep this truth hidden; on Rifò's website, we found the announcement "we believe in our territory that since many generations held a huge textile know-how". It is a sort of recognition of the importance of being located in Prato, one of the most important textile districts in Europe.

Case description

When Niccolò Cipriani, the young Rifò's leader, thought for the first time of a company involved in the sustainability part of the manufacturing, he was far away from Europe. Probably it was for his own culture and sustainability awareness that he was impressed by the effects of ready-to-wear fashion on the whole world.

He was born in October 1990 just around the corner: in Florence, the cradle of the Renaissance, only 15 km distant from Prato. Looking at these places from the sky, a single large city is highlighted, without distinction. Niccolò was still a boy when he moved to Prato with his family where he trained in school.

During his Erasmus program in Rennes, he realizes for the first time the importance of the concept of the circular economy. Thinking about the companies located in Prato, he realized that there was hard work to do to communicate how usually sustainable are fabrics and yarn made by that manufacturers. The heart of the matter was (and is still now) a much more marketing-oriented company to better inform the consumer. As every young student coming from Prato, he usually spent his school holidays in an internship in some local company during summertime. In this case, the uncle's company, a finishing, and dyeing company specializing in fabrics. Niccolò knew a lot about fabrics, yarns, knitwear, woven and cloth.[6]

During his work for a charity in Tanzania, he could see the huge amount of clothes coming from industrialized countries. As probably everyone knows, some international circuits sort second-hand clothes. Generally, winter clothes and a part of summer clothes (in very good condition) remain in Europe; they are sold in charity shops. Summer clothes are sent to Africa, to be sold to the local population at a very low cost. However, about 25% of garments are not reusable at all and they will be recycled and transformed into new fiber. A small part (about 10%) is destined for energy recovery.[7]

It was exactly at that moment (2012) that Niccolò Cipriani first imagined a fashion company to launch a clothing collecting initiative. Together with three Spanish students, he provided an action plan to create a start-up inside his Erasmus project. The program included a separate collection of used clothes, door to door. It was an extraordinary way to collect second-hand clothes, completely irregular. But the project was noticed. BNP Paribas awarded a prize and supported the project. This was a small attempt that will be resumed and expanded later. Niccolò finally graduated from the University of Florence; some years later, in 2014, he took his Master's Degree from Bocconi, Milan.

The further he got from the university, the more autonomous he became, and he soon realized that there were hidden potential opportunities in the green economy. At the end of 2015, after a period of hard work in a buyer office for the world exhibition Expo, Niccolò won the ONU Fellowship Programme for Technical Cooperation Capacity Building and Human Resources Development. This important initiative is financed by the Italian government and management through the Ministry of Foreign Affairs together with United Nations Social. Among its goals, there is to offer young graduates within 28 years the opportunity to carry out a professional training course in developing countries. [8]

This international experience represents an anomaly compared to the experience of many young entrepreneurs in Prato who, before starting their own business, only trained in local companies after having attended technical high school or with their Master's Degree. For the young Cipriani, the destination was Hanoi, the capital of Vietnam, where he remained until 2017. The program aimed to improve microcredit and open up more financial services to poor people in that country. In the

initial phase of his business, Niccolò was involved in microfinance, a sort of social entrepreneur, for a country that deeply needed it. Despite every international and national support, right now Vietnam's microfinance sector continues to underperform its peers in Asia and elsewhere.[9]

In that period companies were born to be global. Entrepreneurs do not automatically buy raw materials from nearby suppliers or set up factories close to their headquarters. They were looking for the planet's best manufacturing locations. In the fashion industry, many production chains were located in the East where costs were significantly lower. This had led to an obvious increase in the consumption of goods at lower costs which, in turn, had triggered overproduction and, finally, an excess of supply. Many well-known brands, even those in the medium-high segments of the market, moved their production centers to low-cost labor countries with an intensification of international trade in semi-finished products and a substantial displacement of the center of gravity of the manufacturing industry. The main countries involved were: Bangladesh, Vietnam, India, and Sri Lanka. The phenomenon in itself would not have been so significant if the investment choices had not been based on the logic of short-term efficiency rather than on the desire to establish roots in the territory to bring economic stability. In some cases, these choices led to intolerable situations of violation of workers' rights, who were underpaid, overworked, and without any sick benefits.

During his stay in Hanoi, Niccolò became aware of the problems related to the overproduction of the clothing industry, the huge traffic of clothes sold in that country at very low prices while the large quantities of surplus were sent to the landfill or incinerator. He figured there was hard work to be done: providing a valid alternative to the global trade in second-hand fast-fashion clothes to stop the outsized affluence of the goods in poor countries; finding an alternative business model to that adopted by the established companies.

When he returned to Italy, the time was ready to start an autonomous entrepreneurial path based on a new model of sustainable production in fashion. Niccolò tried in every way to implement his idea. First of all, he found comfort in the ideas and friendship of an old friend, who was eager to start a small production in a very short range, basing himself on the traditional experience of many companies located in the Prato district. They had played together in swimming ball but they could not find the same harmony that they had developed in sports within their own business.

Niccolò was very determined to consolidate his unconventional business idea, which involves the possibility of recovering 100% of the raw materials from used clothing and knitwear, limiting the use of new fibers. In Prato, almost all companies offered recycled products at the end of the Second World War. Today there are still a considerable number of them, but generally, the articles offered have a much higher proportion of new fibers to give stability to the fabrics, especially for those intended for outwear (coats, jackets…). Niccolò studied the practicability of his project, visiting the so-called "cenciaioli", highly experienced professionals in the sorting of used clothing, able to differentiate each item by weight, color, and fabric composition only by touch. Present in Prato for decades, these people have been in the workforce for many years, in search of a true generational change. From their precious indications, he strengthened the idea of reinterpreting the way of selecting clothes; finally, he prepared a crowdfunding campaign with Clarissa, Michele, and Fiammetta that would allow them to start their beautiful entrepreneurial adventure. The crowdfunding started and in just 30 days about 11500 euros were collected, thanks to Rifò supporters.

Although in the Prato district there is a strong sensibility to the circular economy in wool production, Niccolò, thanks to his experiences in East Asia, was particularly interested in the sustainability of cotton products, which use large tracts of land and need large quantities of water to

bring the plant to maturity. For this reason, too, fashion is believed to be one of the most polluting industries in the world. Rifò's sensitivity to the world of organic cotton started from the promotion of the new T-shirts, a garment widely used by young people and by those who dress sportswear. In April 2018, the crowdfunding campaign for the “100% Regenerated T-shirt” is launched: more than 300 t-shirts are sold in just one month. In that case, Rifò arrived long before the new marketing campaign promoted by Zara which is committed to offering 100% recycled clothes by 2025. (Circulose Collection by Renewcell 2022)[10].

Despite the first evident successes, the confirmation on social networks, and the increasing number of followers, the capital needed to start up a company was still insufficient and it was necessary to find new sources of funding. Fortunately, Rifò was included in a Startup acceleration program created some years before by the Fondazione Cassa di Risparmio di Firenze to finance the innovative ideas of talented young people in the area (Hubble program). It is a 16-week acceleration program and it consists of 4 months of pure venture building. It supports each entrepreneurial project with a grant of up to €50,000, an in-class training program of over 90 hours, digital services with the main players in the market, as well as international and high-profile mentorship, and dedicated workshops. A project where training travels in parallel with the work carried out by each team on its idea, to learn by doing. Hubble takes shape through the collaboration of Nana Bianca, the first startup studio and certified digital incubator in Italy, together with Fondazione Cassa Risparmio di Firenze (Banca Intesa San Paolo) and Fondazione per la Ricerca e l'Innovazione.

Rifò obtained a 50,000 euro loan from Banca Intesa SP; at the end of the year, it set up a limited liability company with the intention of dealing with sustainable production and began a collaboration with Niccolò Corsi of Mashup Lab, which has a wide and consolidated network of relations with companies in the area.

After the personal education of the leader, the initial credit for business is the second anomaly in Rifò’s story. Guaranteeing initial credit to new businesses is a matter of great interest in evaluating the potential of a territory. In post-war Italy, and even before the economic boom of the sixties, many young people started up their businesses by resorting to credit from friends and family.

In Prato, a special mechanism called “intertwined credit” was used for a long time so that young people with a brilliant ideas but no money available could use bank loans based on guarantees from friends, family members, or their customers.[11] The way to re-pay these debts with the customers was to work for free using the scheduling of deliveries (the Italian expression “sconto Lavoro”). Many companies in the industrial districts, but above all many companies from Prato, began their history in this way: they are now household names and successful brands in the fashion system. This very important role of local banks, capable of giving credit to ideas and promoting young people, was an undoubted advantage that has generated a rapid and intense growth of the whole territory. In more recent years, with the adaptation of the banking system to international agreements, with the self-regulation of credit by the Basel Committee, which set itself the objective of identifying and establishing common standards, with the disappearance of local banks and the grouping of banking institutions, everything changed. We can say that now there are many more entry barriers for young people and startuppers. However, there are also valid alternative and very powerful methods of financing, such as crowdfunding campaigns or participation in acceleration programs by business incubators that are linked to leading banking institutions.

Today, knowing how to identify new ways of accessing credit is an advantage that distinguishes the successful young entrepreneur. The Rifò’s team, whose leader is Niccolò Cipriani, has amply demonstrated its ability to access these innovative forms of financing. In February 2020 the first

round of investors brings 30 thousand euros of capital to the startup. These are companies that believe in the value of sustainable fashion: the accelerator Nana Bianca, the Fondazione Cassa di Risparmio di Firenze, Encelado, Economa. In the first months of 2022 a new investment round of 1.5 million euros with 8 partners. In addition to the previous ones, which confirm that they believe in the potential of Rifò, new investors arrive: GM Investimenti of the historic Miroglio textile family in the Alba area; Filpucci, a leading company in the Prato area in the field of fancy yarns of the Gualtieri family, A / impact and Abnormal. The use of this funding is intended to expand clothing collections based on regenerated fibers, and to strengthen the collection service of used clothing in order to transform waste into resources. In addition, a part is intended to strengthen e-commerce sales and strengthen the presence in international markets of Rifò products: Germany followed by Switzerland and Austria. Combined with in-depth marketing and management studies, this access to credit represents the second distinctive element of Rifo's compelling story.

On the strength of the funding obtained and with an established network of relationships, Rifò began its real story, and in June 2019: Martina became the company's first employee in the role of the content creator. Together with the company, there are now 14 permanent employees, with an average age of 29, who carry out service functions, from marketing to time to market, fashion designers, and communication specialists. We are starting to think of “Rifò” as a real brand, regardless of the product. Production is completely carried out in the district, in other manufacturing companies of various sizes, and with various specializations.

In 2019, by the principles of the circular economy, the first jumper regenerated from jeans, 100% Italian, was launched. This is how the collaborative circular economy project "Re-think your jeans" was born, involving consumers in the act of returning old jeans garments that can be used for a regeneration process. From the point of view of product realization, the project is made possible thanks to the collaboration with a company that processes used clothing, Recooper, which also deals with fraying and fiber extraction. There is also a strong partnership with Pinori Filati, an important yarn manufacturer that has been operating in the Prato district for over 50 years. Under the motto "bring denim alive", Pinori Filati has been reinventing yarns from used jeans for over 10 years and has produced an iconic yarn for the circular economy.
From the point of view of circularity and market supply, the project is made possible thanks to the collaboration with the NaturaSi chain of shops, which focuses on sustainable consumption, the fight against food waste, and the protection of biodiversity (119 shops are involved in the project) and has placed cardboard drums in its shops for the collection of clothes. The jeans handed in for recycling give the consumer the opportunity of a discount voucher valid for two years for the purchase of a Rifò garment. The result is a product that is marketed right in Naturasi, also online, under the “Oso” brand, a 100% green fashion brand, made by young people for young people.

A project in which different realities come together, united by a strong commitment to ethics and sustainability. The collections are designed and produced by social tailors coordinated by Rifò in Italian territory engaged with projects of inclusion and job placement. Rifò works with reliable manufacturers who can provide international certifications. Only vegetable raw materials are used, whose production has a minimal impact on the environment, which are long-lasting and can be disposed of without producing toxic waste. Natural fibers such as organic cotton, seaweed, and bamboo fabric, are used to create environmentally friendly garments. The entire production process of the supply chain is outsourced to specialized process step companies located within a 30 km radius of Rifò. With Rifò’s philosophy, after the globalization phase, fashion returns to the value of

being a production located, localized, and anchored to the territory and its competencies.

The last anomaly that distinguishes Rifò from the other companies in Prato concerns the possibility to be recognized with its brand by the final consumer; above all, the commitment to the use of new information technologies to reach the consumer in real-time. Sustainability and digitalization are the predominant drivers to expand the company. The approximately 18.500 items of clothing made during 2021 by Rifò with regenerated materials are 100% made in Italy and are sold in over 100 stores around the world and directly online thanks to a collaboration agreement established with the marketplace Zalando. It provides free delivery throughout Italy for purchases over 100 euros. All these pieces of information are well highlighted in an extremely articulate “Sustainability Report” for the year 2020 that Rifò has produced to inform all its customers and the potential ones. It has been published in full on the company’s website. Reading that report, people learn that last year, about 8.500 old cashmere sweaters were transformed into new fibers for Rifò’s products.

Percentage of regenerated and virgin fibers on total production 2020 Rifò

Regenerated cashmere	62
Regenerated cotton	27
Virgin cotton	05
Virgin wool	03
Regenerated polyester	02

Other regenerated fibers	01
TOTAL	100

Source: www.rifo-lab.com

The report mentions also the difficult task of fibers procurement. Wool and cashmere are fibers that fall into the post-consumer category; they are derived from used or discarded clothing from North America and Southern Europe. Cotton, on the other hand, is a pre-consumer category fiber, that is derived from industrial waste to be disposed of. It is more difficult to recover cotton from used garments because it is normally found with other man-made fibers in a mixed composition that is mainly synthetic.

The absolute transparency of Rifo's information characterized the company's communication style. For incentivizing the aspects related to marketing communication Rifò took part in Wem Park Laboratory at PIN, the Prato center of the University of Florence. This allowed the creation of a website in direct contact with supporters and awareness campaigns that have increased the number of young people gravitating around the brand. There is a large group of supporters on Facebook: there are about two thousand of them. A " fidelity" program will soon be launched to acquire information and keep up to date on the most faithful customers.

Inside the website, there is a blog updated in real-time with all the information about the brand, Rifò's participation in conferences and events[12], and where they are usually included useful insights about the theme of sustainability in fashion with various distinctions between natural fibers, animal fibers, and artificial fibers. This represents an excellent way to educate the consumer about Rifò's philosophy which is to produce only what is needed to avoid overproduction.

The appropriate and progressive use of e-commerce has helped the company to overcome the difficult times of the coronavirus pandemic, which practically paralyzed Italian manufacturing and suffered very substantial consequences from the forced closure of stores and sales outlets. The clients are now almost 15.000, 70% in Italy and 30% abroad. The online sales platform is not the only marketing channel for Rifò's products; there are also connections with 250 stores, 50% in Italy and 50% abroad, mainly in Germany, Austria, and Switzerland.

That's why all Rifò's numbers are marked positive (employees, turnover…) even during the difficult years of the pandemic. The establishment of the Rifò brand came during the 2021 Christmas Holidays when Intesa San Paolo banking group, which had financed the start-up a few years earlier, decided to donate to ist consultants all over Italy a 100% recycled cashmere scarf made by Rifò. 8 thousand scarves were produced for this new prominent customer.

This direct relationship with the evolved consumer, sensitive to respect for the environment and people's rights, represents another distinctive feature of Rifò's brand; the success of the company shows us that the road taken is the right one, compared to the average of companies in the Prato district, used to working continuously without necessarily keeping costumers and consumers informed. Rifò, on the other hand, finds itself in the embarrassment of having to grow in size but at the same time having to economize on production in order not to fall into the trap of overproduction. This paradox is experienced by the leader Niccolò Cipriani with the commitment of those who work as if they were "walking on a high wire". Certainly, it will be possible to contain this paradox as long as production quantities are contained. But the company's philosophy is inspired by the "Less is more" motto.

Discussion and conclusion

In 2021, the European apparel and textile confederation Euratex13 realized a comparative study to establish the sectoral skill strategy for textile, clothing, and leather referring to the situation of the industry in 2030. They developed 5 scenarios to establish a set of recommendations and strategies for the stakeholders (education, industry, and policymakers). According to that situation, Rifò could be one of the main characters of the medium scenario, called “Renaissance of the craft” in which the company will combine heritage with technological developments for a range of goods from different price levels produced locally. The scenario considers the change in consumer behaviors, which have become more conscious and sustainable, giving rise to local models of recycling based on traditional concepts but enhanced by technology[14]. In this scenario, the main characteristic that moves the new consumer is a great awareness of sustainability and circular economy. This is exactly what Rifò is doing now with its transparent, detailed, and comprehensive marketing strategy.

Rifò’s line also includes attention to product packaging and distribution. All packaging is sustainable and uses recycled and recyclable materials such as cardboard. However, in the company’s plans, there is the desire to replace cardboard with packaging made directly from recycled fabric from the Prato district. In addition, the company proposes the repack service, which infinitely reuses the external package.[15]

For all these reasons Rifò, since its establishment, has participated in all editions of the "Fashion Revolution Week" a very important annual event for sustainable and ethical fashion. Organized by Fashion Revolution, a global non-profit movement present in over 100 countries in the world founded in 2013 after the tragic events of the Rana Plaza in Savar, Bangladesh, where thousands of people lost their lives in precarious working conditions for the collapse of an old building used as a manufacturing factory. [16]They were all working for the world's top fashion brands. Fashion Revolution's annual event aims to make consumers aware of many untold stories about manufacturing processes and hopes to involve international fashion brands in raising awareness of sustainability.

Rifò was also present at the first Fashion Revolution week, organized in Turin in 2018, whose motto was "Be curious. Find out. Do something".

In the edition of 2022, which will take place as every year in the last days of April in memory of the tragic events, there will be a guided tour of the companies in the Prato district that normally collaborate with Rifò to explain to a wide audience the circular economy with a project of "Open Factories"

The company Rifò has received an honorable mention in the ninth edition of the “Premio Santo Stefano per il Lavoro”, an award strongly desired by the local Institutions that every year give a certificate to some deserving companies, ethically irreproachable and environmentally friendly. The motivation for Rifò was based on its project of enhancing the circular economy, perfectly eco-sustainable, according to the ancient tradition of re-use that has made the city of Prato great over the years.

One of the last frontiers of Rifò consists in the commitment to professional training. Once again Rifò is the main actor in a training project based on the “cenciaiolo” figure. The project involves various local actors for good causes: teaching people who have had various problems at work and

giving them new job opportunities. As usual, some leader companies of Prato join with Rifò and finaced the project: Beste, Filpucci, Lanificio Mario Bellucci, Milior and M&A with a total amount of 10 .000 euros. Rifò itself financed the project with a further 15 thousand euros. Municipality of Prato, the artisan association Cna, Astri Consortium, Fil (education and training office), Consorzio Detox, and Opera Santa Rita are partners of the project which is intended for vulnerable subjects such as asylum seekers or victims of labor exploitation. This new initiative marks a further acceleration in Rifò's ecological strategy which has chosen to strengthen ethical sustainability concerning only environmental sustainability. "Nei nostri panni. Cenciaioli si diventa" is the funny name of the project that plays with the meaning of the words: "In our shoes, to become cenciaiolo". It is a symbolic commitment since training courses have been developed for only five people, which will be hosted by historic rags sorting companies. But the meaning deserves great praise both because some unfortunate foreigners are ennobled in the Prato district and because they try to solve a real problem for the local industry: the need for a valid generational change in some key functions of the supply chain. If this project leads to good results shortly there will be the possibility of being able to repeat the experience thinking of other professional figures whose lack has been felt in recent times: spinners and weavers, for example.

Great attention to social issues as well. With the "2loveprato" campaign, Rifò has allocated two euros for each garment sold to some no-profit local associations reaching more than 6 thousand euros in donations in 2020. A significant part of these donations went to Santo Stefano hospital in Prato for the purchase of masks and other necessities caused by the coronavirus pandemic situation.

In 2020 the new rifò headquarters was inaugurated, a 750 square meter co-working space on two levels where is possible to visit the collection and bring back used clothes to be put into the production cycle. A recent agreement with Muji shops in Milan has enabled the company to expand its collection points in Italy. (www.muji.com)

Since 2020 Rifò has been certified as a B Corporation. It means that it is a company that generates a positive impact on the environment, respecting social standards, responsibility, and transparency.

Rifò is an artisan company associated with CNA Toscana Centro that has decided to join the extraordinary Astri Consortium, a transversal group of more than 130 companies born in 2000 and located in Prato: ferrymen to old rag-and-bone men, dealers, finishings, wool mills, and dyeing groups. (www.astrirecycling.it) They make the circular economy a daily commitment.

For the future, Rifo is thinking about a sustainable total look that goes from a series of products to packaging and communication via App. In this way, Rifo proves to be a very modern company, with strong roots in the Prato district but with a great vocation to the digital economy. But there is also a dream that with recent funding could come true: a series of innovative textile products for the home furnishing sector. Nicolò Cipriani represents an authentic Tuscan entrepreneur, an innovator that looks ahead with the awareness of his own culture. That is exactly what we know also in Italian literature when we read that: "Tuscany is a magical landscape where everything around is kind; everything is both ancient and new" (Curzio Malaparte).

[11] K.P.Pucker "the Myth of Sustainable Fashion" Harvard Business Review, January 2022

[2] "Prato: The Italian town turning rags into new clothes" BBC News, 16 December 2020

[3] G. Becattini "Caterpillar and Butterfly" Mondadori Education, 2004; G. Becattini, M. Bellandi, G. Dei Ottati, F.Sforzi "From industrial districts to local development" Books, 2003

[4] Data Confindustria Toscana Nord, 2022

[5] M. Laurenti, M. Trentin (a cura di) "Ecosistema urbano 2021. Rapporto sulle performance ambientali delle città" Legambiente

[6] In the textile industry people learn best how to do the job directly from practice. School desks are necessary but not sufficient to give a complete knowledge of the processes. The case of clothing, however, is different, because everyone can learn to sew with a little effort and lots of practise. Growing up in an industrial district helps a lot because you get to see the production and learn the secrets of the craft.

[7] www.raccoltavestiti.humanaitalia.org

[8] From the beginning (1999) almost 635 young Italian professionals have participated in the Program

[9] Ron Bevaqua, Duong (Sophie) Nguyen, Don Lambert "Reimagining Vietnam's microfinance sector. Recommendations for institutional and legal reform" in Asian development Bank Southeast Asia working paper Series, number 20, November 2021

[10] Renewcell, the most innovative Companies 2021, is a multi-award-winning sustain tech company based in Sweden. Renewcell can upcycle cellulosic textile waste (such as cotton clothes) transforming it into new material, Circulose, which was included on Time Magazine's list of the 100 best innovations 2020.

[11] G. Dei Ottati, "Trust, interlinking transactions and credit in the industrial district" Cambridge Journal of Economics 18 (6), 524-546, 1994

[12] For example, the appreciated participation of Niccolò Cipriani at tedxFirenze in 2020 to talk about the circular economy; the interview in "#Storiesdisuccesso" by A.Tripodi in www.stream24.il Sole24ore.com, 01/03/2022

[13] European textile & clothing national associations and European branch associations have entrusted EURATEX with their representation at European Union level and with the defense and promotion of their common interests (www.euratex.eu)

[14]Katarzyna Sulisz policy officer Euratex " Sectoral skills strategy for TCBL industries in 2030" in "Il Futuro dell'industria della Moda" Pitti Uomo, Firenze 12 gennaio 2022

[15] www.originalrepack.com

[16] see the docufilm "The true cost" (www.truecostmovie.com)